

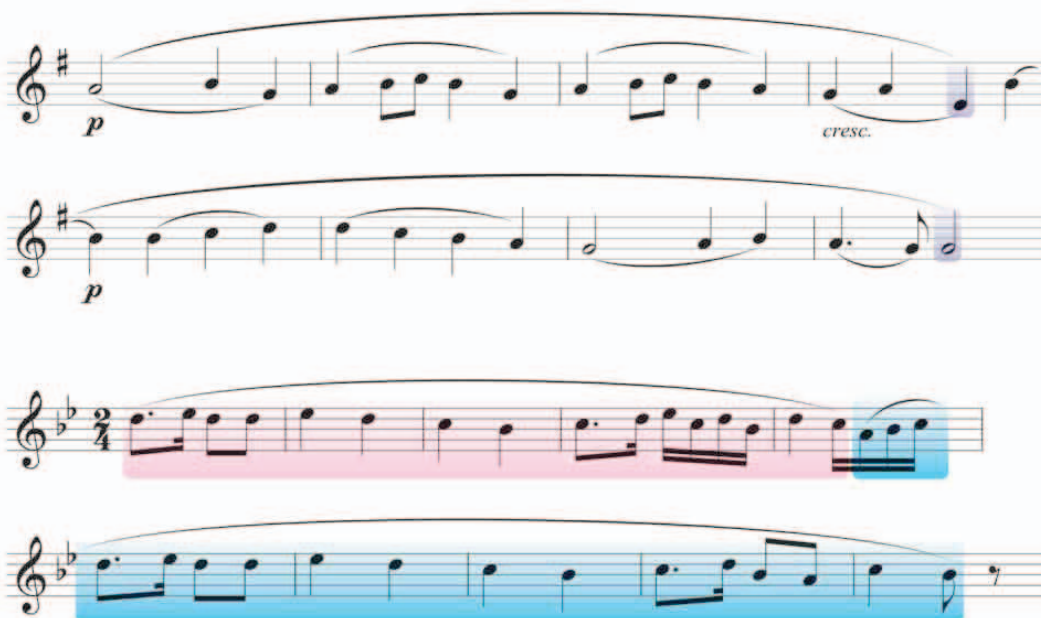
Phrase lengths

Phrase lengths of four and eight measures are most common in music, and melodies are often composed of several consecutive phrases put together. Regardless of the length, a phrase has meaningful structure, with a beginning, a period of forward motion, and a definite cadence, or stopping point.

REAL WORLD

Circular breathing

While breathing is typically considered an integral part of musical phrasing, some wind players train themselves to do circular breathing—taking air in through the nose while simultaneously pushing air out through the mouth, removing the necessity of stopping the sound to take a breath. Smooth jazz saxophonist Kenny G once held a note for almost 46 minutes!



◁ Four-bar phrases

Shown here are the last eight bars of “Ode to Joy,” which has four four-measure phrases. The penultimate phrase ends on an expectant-sounding so (scale degree 5), and the quarter rest here makes a clean break before the last phrase.

◁ Other phrase lengths

Four- and eight-measure phrases are most common, but other phrase lengths can be found, like the five-measure phrases in Haydn’s *Variations on a Theme*. The second phrase begins with three quick pick-up notes in measure five.

LOOKING CLOSER

Phrase endings

Phrase endings are logical places for musicians to break or pause in their playing, signaling to listeners that what follows begins a new musical thought. Musical notation may include symbols directing musicians when to pause.



△ Comma

The conventional place to breathe is at the end of a phrase, sometimes also indicated with a comma.



△ Up-bow

An up-bow may reinforce a composer’s phrasing choices; this symbol may indicate lifting the bow at the end of a phrase.



△ Down-bow

The down-bow instructs players to reset the bow on the strings; it may be used for a strong downbeat at the beginning of a phrase.